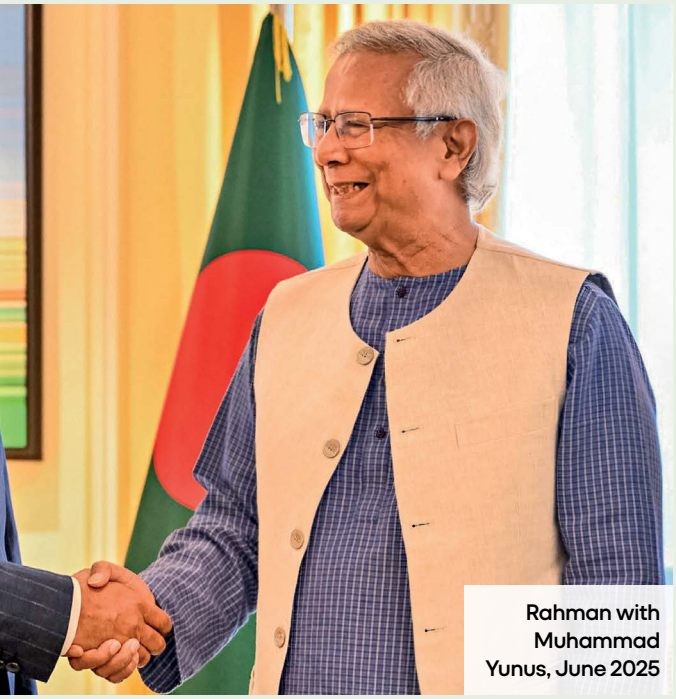


Rahman with Muhammad Yunus, June 2025

their daughter, Zaima, now a barrister, Rahman remained closely engaged with party affairs. He addressed party workers through virtual meetings or recorded messages, including the BNP's fifth National Council in 2009, where he was elected senior vice-chairman. Observers who tracked his evolution describe a softer public tone, greater willingness to delegate and a sharper instinct for coalition-building than the combative figure of the early 2000s.

That shift crystallised after the youth-led uprising of 2024 dismantled the long rule of Sheikh Hasina and ushered in an interim administration. When Rahman returned to Dhaka in December 2025, it was less as an avenger than as a survivor. The election that followed delivered a decisive mandate. Whether his personal transformation can translate into national healing is the question Bangladesh must now confront. ■

—ADM

ing India's strategic and economic role in the region but also encouraging it to become part of the China-centric economic corridor that Bangladesh itself was veering toward.

This led to tit-for-tat retaliation in bilateral trade, with both countries tightening land border movement and thereby increasing logistics costs. Bangladesh, for example, restricted trade through land customs stations, forcing traders to use the sea route via the congested Chittagong port, which caused delays and drove up costs. In response, India restricted the movement of Bangladeshi goods through 11 land customs stations along the roughly 4,096 km Indo-Bangladesh border. These measures affected nearly 42 per cent of the $14 billion (Rs 1.27 lakh crore) in annual India-Bangladesh trade.

Relations soured further when the Yunus government cancelled the Indian Special Economic Zones originally planned in 2015 and indicated that the land might be repurposed for a defence industrial park. India responded by cutting its financial aid to Bangladesh by half—from Rs 120 crore the previous year to Rs 60 crore in this year's budget. India had earlier extended an $8 billion (Rs 73,000 crore) line of credit to Bangladesh, though not all of it was utilised. Several infrastructure and connectivity projects have since stalled, and Indian technical experts have left Bangladesh, citing security concerns. At the same time, Dhaka has begun signalling a shift in priorities, exploring partnerships with other international players, especially China.

ANTI-HINDU WORRIES

In the initial days of the Yunus regime, as the law-and-order situation spiralled out of control, India expressed concern over the widespread targeting of minority Hindus, who, at around 13 million, account for 8 per cent of Bangladesh's 175 million population. More than 2,000 such communal incidents, including the vandalisation of temples, were reportedly recorded. The Yunus regime

IN RESPONSE TO DHAKA CANCELLING INDIAN SEZs, DELHI CUT ITS FINANCIAL AID TO BANGLADESH FROM ₹120 CRORE THE PREVIOUS YEAR TO ₹60 CRORE IN THIS YEAR'S BUDGET

denied these figures. Meanwhile, when a group of protesters breached the Bangladesh Assistant High Commission in Agartala, Tripura, in December 2024, Dhaka described the incident as "a violation of the Vienna Convention" and "unacceptable". India, on its part, termed the incident "deeply regrettable" and said it would take action against the perpetrators. Bangladesh has also consistently charged India with persecuting Muslims under the pretext that they are of Bangladeshi origin. Stopping killings at the border was another major promise in the BNP manifesto and campaign.

Though communal violence had largely been brought under control in the past year, unrest returned to Dhaka in December 2025 when prominent Bangladeshi student leader Sharif Osman Hadi was killed in Dhaka. Known for his anti-India rhetoric, his death on December 18 saw demonstrations being held against the Indian High Commission in Dhaka. The same day, Dipu Chandra Das, a garment factory worker in Mymensingh, was lynched by a mob, ostensibly for making anti-Islam remarks. As a precautionary